

# Banana skipper

*Erionota thrax* Banana skipper, banana leaf roller, hesperiid butterfly, palm redeye

|                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Prevention                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | Monitoring                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | Direct Control                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |
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|  <p>Banana leaves with rolls of larvae of <i>E. thrax</i> (R. de Jong)</p>  <p>Egg cluster underneath the leaf (S.S. Weligamage)</p>  <p>Leaf roll opened to show almost full-grown larva of <i>E. thrax</i>; black pills to the left are accumulated droppings (R. de Jong)</p> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Banana skipper is a butterfly which causes damage to leaves as a caterpillar.</li> <li>Eggs can easily spread on banana leaves so use clean planting material from certified sources.</li> <li>Practice good sanitation by removing plant matter on the ground - burn or deeply bury to 50 cm.</li> <li>Encourage the presence of natural enemies such as insectivorous birds, parasitic wasps and parasitic flies:</li> <li>Conserve nearby trees and shrubs where birds may perch and feed.</li> <li>Avoid the use of pesticides if possible, or only use botanical (plant-derived) sprays since they are less harmful to insects.</li> <li>Do not transport infected banana leaves or plants outside of the plantation.</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Look out for:</li> <li>Adult/butterfly: brown with three yellow spots on the forewings. Large head with large red eyes and thickened antennae tips, wingspan 70-80 mm. It flies during early evening and early morning.</li> <li>Caterpillar: Pale green, shiny black head, up to 6 cm long. Young caterpillars are usually covered in a white waxy powder.</li> <li>Pupae: yellow-brown, 4-6 cm long, covered in white wax, found inside leaf rolls.</li> <li>Eggs: yellow, 2 mm wide, single or in groups of 25, on underside of banana leaves.</li> <li>Leaf rolls up to 15 cm long, usually containing caterpillars.</li> <li>Severe infestation will result in just the leaf midrib remaining and large cigar-shaped cases (leaf rolls) hanging from it.</li> </ul> | <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>If the infestation is low, hand remove leaf rolls and any visible caterpillars, pupae and eggs:</li> <li>Place eggs and caterpillars in a screened box close to banana plants so that parasitic wasps can emerge and parasitize other caterpillars.</li> <li>Destroy plant debris, pupae and caterpillars by burning, or crush caterpillars and pupae and deeply bury plant debris to at least 50 cm.</li> <li>Spray plants with a neem product. Refer to the product label for application guidance.</li> <li>Use biological controls such as the parasitoids <i>Apanteles erionotae</i> and <i>Ooencyrtus erionotae</i>, if available in your country. Check with your local authority whether parasitoid specificity must be established before larval parasitoids are introduced.</li> </ul> |

Note: Pesticides may be available to control this pest. Please check with the Ministry of Agriculture in your country to find out which pesticides are registered in your country and the local restrictions for their use.